THE SERPENT HOLDER

Ophiuchus

SIZE RANKING 11

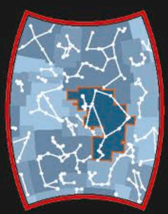
BRIGHTEST STAR Rasalhague (α) 2.1

GENITIVE Ophiuchi

ABBREVIATION Oph

HIGHEST IN SKY AT 10 PM June–July

FULLY VISIBLE 59°N–75°S



This large constellation straddling the celestial equator depicts a man holding a snake. The head of Ophiuchus adjoins Hercules in the north, while his feet rest on Scorpius in the south. The Sun passes through Ophiuchus in the first half of December, but despite this, the constellation is not regarded as a true member of the zodiac.

Ophiuchus was the site of the last supernova explosion seen in our galaxy, which appeared in 1604. It far outshone all other stars and is known as Kepler's Star (see p.273) after Johannes Kepler, who wrote about it in *De stella nova* (see p.68).

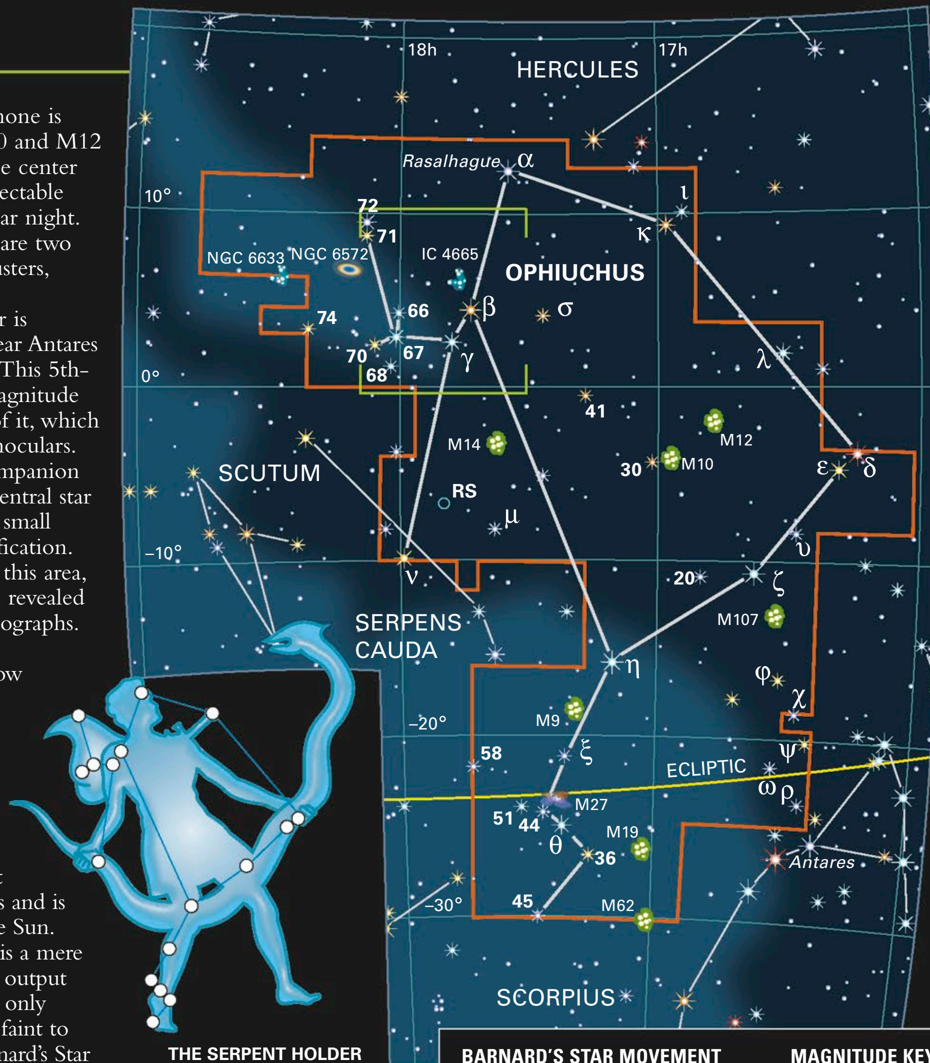
SPECIFIC FEATURES

Lying on the edge of the Milky Way, in the direction of the center of our galaxy, Ophiuchus contains numerous star clusters. Messier cataloged seven globular clusters, although none is particularly prominent. M10 and M12 (see p.295) are both near the center of the constellation and detectable through binoculars on a clear night. Better sights for binoculars are two large and scattered open clusters, NGC 6633 and IC 4665.

An amazing multiple star is Rho (ρ) Ophiuchi, lying near Antares (in neighboring Scorpius). This 5th-magnitude star has a 7th-magnitude companion on either side of it, which are best viewed through binoculars. Another 6th-magnitude companion that is much closer to the central star can be identified through a small telescope using high magnification. The complex nebulosity in this area, including around Antares, is revealed only in long-exposure photographs.

The beautiful double star 70 Ophiuchi consists of yellow and orange dwarfs, with components of 4th and 6th magnitudes, while the double star 36 Ophiuchi is a pair of orange dwarfs with components of 5th magnitude.

Barnard's Star is the most celebrated star in Ophiuchus and is the second-closest star to the Sun. Even though this red dwarf is a mere 5.9 light-years away, its light output is so feeble that it appears as only magnitude 9.5, and it is too faint to see without a telescope. Barnard's Star is moving so quickly relative to the background stars that its change in position is noticeable over a matter of only a few years (see chart, right).



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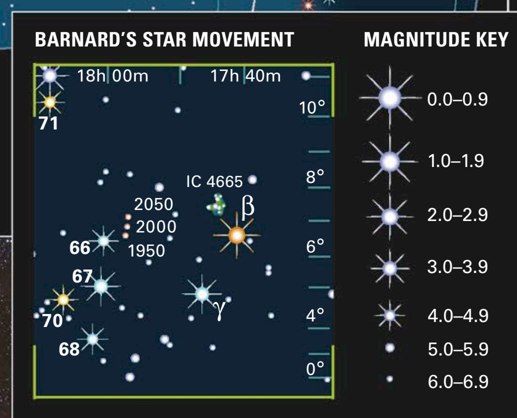
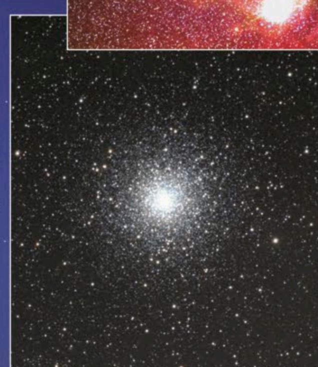


INTRICATE NEBULOSITY
Complex nebulosity extends from the area around Rho (ρ) Ophiuchi (at the top of the image below), southward to Antares (bottom).



M10
The large globular cluster M10 is some 14,000 light-years away. Like its neighbor M12, it is detectable through binoculars on a clear night.

SNAKE MAN
Ophiuchus represents a man wrapped in the coils of a huge snake, the constellation Serpens. The ecliptic runs through Ophiuchus, and planets can be seen within its borders.

MYTHS AND STORIES

ASCLEPIUS

Ophiuchus is identified with Asclepius, the Greek god of medicine who reputedly had the power to revive the dead. Hades, god of the Underworld, feared that this ability endangered his trade in dead souls and asked Zeus to strike Asclepius down. Zeus then placed the great healer among the stars.

RESTORATIVE POWERS
Asclepius is watched as he heals a female patient, in this 5th-century BCE marble relief from Piraeus, Greece.